India away from Russia," he says.

The US is aiming for a deal involving fighter jets for the navy's indigenous aircraft carrier INS *Vikrant*, but the F/A-18 Super Hornet faces a stiff challenge from French firm Dassault's Rafale Marine. The US is also in the race for a $20 billion IAF proposal to buy 114 multi-role fighter aircraft.

Today's India-US military ties have grown on the back of "foundational agreements" signed by the two countries: the Logistic Exchange Memorandum of Agreement (LEMOA), signed in August 2016; the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement (COMCASA), signed in September 2018; and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement (BECA) for geo-spatial cooperation, signed in 2020. India and the US signed the Industrial Security Annex (ISA) to the General Security of Military Information Agreement (GSOMIA) in December 2019, enabling the US private sector defence industry to share classified information and technology with their Indian counterparts.

Akriti (Vasudeva) Kalyankar, Fellow in the Stimson Center's South Asia Program, says the US and India have been trying to figure out how to co-produce and co-develop defence equipment. "This has been driven by Washington and Delhi's aligning threat perceptions vis-a-vis China and the desire to bolster Delhi's material capabilities," she says, adding that various efforts towards this, like the DTTI, launched in 2012, had not come to fruition largely due to US hesitation towards technology transfer. The iCET, Kalyankar says, seems significant, particularly as a symbol of the high-level political commitment to figure out these issues. "And it is driven by concerns in both Washington and Delhi on the over-reliance of the Indian military on equipment of Russian/Soviet origin."

Harsh Pant, head of the strategic studies programme at the Observer Research Foundation, says that iCET is an important initiative when technology is at the heart of global political discourse. "This partnership is likely to grow because strategic convergence between the US and India at this point is extremely high. While we may have certain reservations about US foreign policy towards India, strategic vision brings the two countries together," Pant says.

The new Indo-US dynamics could be seen at the recently concluded Aero India 2023 show at the Yelahanka air force base in Bengaluru. The five-day event was dominated by the US, with the largest-ever US delegation participating in Asia's biggest military aviation exhibition. The US Air Force's stealth F-35 fighter made its maiden appearance in India, and was the show-stopper with its cutting-edge manoeuvres. An F-16 Fighting Falcon fighter and a B-1 Lancer strategic bomber conducted daily aerial demonstrations over the Bengaluru sky. On static display were the F/A-18E and F/A-18F Super Hornet, both multirole fighter jets.

In fact, only US and Indian aircraft were kept on display at the Yelahanka IAF base. India's key ally Russia was under-represented, with minimal presence of its representatives at the various events. Russian state-owned weapons exporter Rosoboronexport had a joint stall with Russian aerospace giant United Aircraft Corporation (UAC) and state-owned Almaz-Antey, displaying miniature models of aircraft, trucks, radars and tanks, marked a nominal presence.

INDIA'S IMPORTED ARSENAL

RUSSIAN ORIGIN PLATFORMS DOMINATE THE INDIAN MILITARY. NOW, US HARDWARE IS SLOWLY INCREASING ITS PRESENCE



RUSSIAN-MADE WEAPONRY IN THE INDIAN MILITARY

INDIAN ARMY

- T-90 and T-72 tanks
- Konkurs and Korent anti-tank guided missiles
- Surface-to-air missiles like Osa, Pechora, Strela, Igla
- AK-47 assault rifle
- Smerch and Grad, the multiple rocket launcher systems

INDIAN NAVY

- Surface ships: Rajput-class destroyers; Talwar-class frigates; Veer-class missile corvettes
- Kilo-class conventional submarines
- Nuclear-powered submarine INS *Chakra*

THE RUSSIA HAND

However, Russia has always been a staunch ally of India, offering technical assistance, transfers of technology and co-development, as in the BrahMos missile. Throughout the Cold War and till date, Russia has supplied India with a wide range of weapons—from tanks to missiles, aircraft and